

INTERNATIONAL

UFO

REPORTER

MARCH/APRIL 1985
Vol. 10 No. 2
ISSN. #0730-174X



Hessdalen Lights...page 10



Russell Croop

J. Allen Hynek

Editor-in-chief
J. Allen Hynek

Editor
Jerome Clark

Consulting Editor
Richard Hall

Contributing Editors
Bill Chalker
Roberto Pinotti
Bob Pratt
Mark Rodeghier
Richard Sigismund
Willy Smith

Production Manager
Sherman J. Larsen

Make-up Editor
Ann E. Parker

Artists
Caroline Baum
Edith Bonhivert

INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER (ISSN, #0720-174X) is published bimonthly by the CENTER FOR UFO STUDIES, 1955 John's Drive, Glenview, Illinois 60025. All rights reserved. Reproduction without permission is strictly prohibited. ©Copyright 1985 by Center for UFO Studies, Third Class postage paid at Glenview, Illinois.

Address all editorial correspondence to INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER, Jerome Clark, Editor, 1511 Greenleaf Street, Evanston, Illinois 60202.

Address all subscription correspondence to INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER, 1955 John's Drive, Glenview, Illinois 60025, (312) 724-2480.

The INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER is a benefit publication mailed to ASSOCIATES of the Center for UFO Studies contributing \$20.00 or more to the Center for UFO Studies. Foreign ASSOCIATES add \$5.00 for surface or \$10.00 for airmail delivery. All amounts in U.S. funds. Other publications also available to contributors of larger amounts. For details, write to 1955 John's Drive, Glenview, Illinois 60025, USA. POSTMASTER: Send Form 3579 to CUFOS, P.O. Box 1621, Lima, Ohio 45802.

A Ufology for the 1980s

We are living in a curious—and I think crucial—moment in UFO history.

For one thing, since 1947 there has never been a period that has seen so little UFO activity. Sightings of anomalous aerial phenomena are still being made—see, for example, the articles by J. Allen Hynek and Bruce Maccabee in this issue—but they are rare. The most widely-publicized sightings of recent years—the Westchester County, New York, “boomerang”—are a subject of dispute even among CUFOS staffers, some of whom (I am one) are satisfied with the light-plane identification. (Dr. Hynek, who investigated some of the sightings personally, as I have not, disagrees.) A spectacular “UFO” observed in the Soviet Union this past January has certain suspicious features in common with past Russian “UFOs” which turn out to have been caused by secret satellite launches.

It remains to be seen whether the absence of significant UFO activity is a fluke or whether it marks a return to things as they were before 1947, when UFOs were so rarely sighted that society at large didn't even have a name for them. Now, of course, the firm place UFOs occupy in popular culture will assure the survival of flying-saucer mythology for some time to come, even in the relative absence of sightings.

Yet it would be disastrous if that were to be the only way in which UFOs will continue to command attention. Some ufologists, however, seem willing to settle for that. Some profess to take heart from the fact, for example, that the Summer 1984 Olympics ended with the staged landing of a giant “UFO.” Unfortunately, such events serve only to trivialize our subject and to encourage the view (already too widely held among scientifically-trained persons whom ufologists supposedly are trying to impress with their evidence) that UFOs are only a silly spectacle.

If ufology is to survive, the last thing it needs is the kind of naive boosterism that cheers any public affirmation of the UFO image. Ufology will survive as a scientifically meaningful activity only if it demonstrates that its methods of inquiry are valid to document the presence of what may be an extraordinary anomaly. That should be, and must be, its primary concern. Fortunately, there is more serious ufology going on today than ever in the history of UFO research. The best of it will be appearing in the pages of *IUR*.

At the same time it is also true that credulity and loose thinking plague UFO inquiry as they always have. A serious ufology, a 1980s ufology that seeks to learn from the past and to separate itself from the mistakes of its predecessors, will have to set housecleaning as one of its immediate tasks. We certainly will never know what UFOs are if we don't know what they are not. Mystery-mongering, which might be defined as the pursuit of wonder instead of answers, is not what we are about.

IUR's editorial position is simply that UFOs are a serious question which deserves serious attention. Beyond that we hold forth for no particular interpretation. We ask only that those who do interpret UFO data and develop hypotheses from them—whether these individuals define themselves as proponents, skeptics or neutrals—make sure that their ideas are soundly based in reason and evidence. *IUR* has begun a series of articles that examine popular theories about UFOs to see how well they withstand critical scrutiny. In our last issue Jenny Randles argued “The Case Against the IFO.” In this issue D. Scott Rogo reviews the controversy surrounding a much-publicized experiment involving imagined UFO abductions.

Even if we are entering a long lull in sightings, we 1980s ufologists have nearly four decades of reports, claims, controversies and unanswered (or misanswered) questions with which to concern ourselves. Even if the UFO mystery itself remains unsolved, by now those ufologists willing to heed the lessons have learned much about proper investigation and analysis. Research into what the United States government does or does not know about UFOs, for example, is on the whole more sophisticated—and more credible—than it was in the 1950s when accusations of official cover-ups seemed based in little more than UFO-buff paranoia. True, this changed situation has something to do with the Freedom of Information Act, but it also has to do with the skills investigators have acquired as they have painstakingly pursued the leads.

Something is out there—something that science has paid too little attention to and that the public has paid too much of the wrong kind of attention to. It's time now for a mature ufology to address itself, in the right way, to the real issues. —Jerome Clark.

IMAGINARY FACTS:

To those ufologists who accept the physical reality of the UFO abduction phenomenon, no challenge seemed greater than that posed by a series of reports written by Dr. Alvin Lawson in 1977.

Beginning in that year, Lawson, an English professor at California State University at Long Beach, undertook a curious project. He recruited several volunteer subjects, had them hypnotized and asked them to imagine what it would be like to be abducted by a UFO. (The hypnosis was implemented by Dr. William McCall, a prominent California physician.) The sessions were highly structured, with each subject being asked a series of specific questions to help guide his responses. He was to describe the imaginary UFO; the manner in which the abduction took place; the inside of the craft; the alien beings in charge; the way a physical examination was carried out; a message hypothetically given by the aliens; the method by which the subject was returned from the UFO; and any aftermath to the event.

Lawson used 16 subjects, whose accounts he subsequently compared to a handful of "genuine" cases extracted from the literature. When he found no substantial differences between them, he concluded that, like imaginary abduction narratives, "real-life" abduction stories are psychological in origin.

Lawson had reached a bold conclusion but he was confident enough to present it to the UFO community in a paper delivered to the 1977 MUFON UFO Symposium held in Scottsdale, Arizona. The next year he reported his findings to the Toronto convention of the American Psychological Association. His research attracted additional attention when *Science News* featured it in February 1978. His work was described in other popular magazines and in general received a remarkable amount of media attention. His claims endeared him to the debunkers and caused many researchers to entertain doubts about the validity of the abduction phenomenon.

But what was the basis for these apparent hallucinatory episodes? Early on Lawson toyed with the idea that they were based on information contained within the human

by D. Scott Rogo

memory system. He had noted that many of his imaginary abductees reported experiences obviously drawn from their own lives. (For example, many based the descriptions of their physical examinations on operations or treatments they had undergone.) In due course Lawson was comparing the reported experiences of UFO abductees to birth experiences. He extracted what he perceived to be "birth imagery" in several abduction reports—images of journeying down a tunnel, floating in fluid while aboard a UFO, seeing the embryonic shapes of aliens, entering into a brightly-lit arena, and so on.

But Lawson was not interested merely in making such interesting observations; he also wanted to test his—if you will pardon the pun—newborn theory. Once more he relied on his imaginary abduction protocol. This time, however, he compared the narratives told by subjects who had undergone normal births to several who had been born through cesarean section. He found considerable tunnel imagery in the first group and very little in the second. Lawson went on to propose that UFO abduction experiences are birth memories which—at crucial times—take on a hallucinatory form.

This necessarily brief summary describes the evolution of Lawson's thought from 1977 through 1984. I have outlined it as a prelude to a presentation of my own views, which will occupy the rest of this article.

I believe that Lawson's evidence is based on a crucially flawed methodology; that his evaluations are contaminated by several sources of bias and experimental error; and that there currently exists no objective evidence supporting any of his views or theories.

To explain how I came to these conclusions, let us examine how Lawson conducted his research, understanding that several cardinal rules dictate the conduct of scientific research. As I will show, Lawson and his colleagues violated just about all of them.

The first thing the critical reader of Lawson's research will note is that *his imaginary abduction scenarios were elicited through the use of deliberately-phrased questions*. This procedure helped the subjects to relate stories that conformed to those related by real-life abductees. The problem is compounded by the fact that Lawson's subjects, even though they were screened concerning their knowledge of UFOs, were no doubt familiar with certain basic ideas about UFOs and their occupants. This information could have been picked up from newspaper stories, science-fiction movies and a host of other sources. Of course, when we consider the pervasiveness of UFO information and misinformation in circulation since the late 1940s, we have to grant this is a problem that probably no experimenter could have surmounted.

But the more closely one reads Lawson's papers, the more evident it becomes that other sources of bias could have contaminated his research even further. One major problem has to do with Lawson's decision to ask Dr. McCall to conduct the hypnosis sessions. Lawson did so because *McCall had worked in the past with several persons claiming time-lapse abduction experiences*. He was a logical choice but a poor one.

As a man familiar with the pattern and content of typical abduction stories, McCall could have directed the subjects—through cues or leading questions—into making the very responses he expected or was hoping for. I wish to emphasize that this is only a possibility. We will not know for certain until Lawson publishes complete transcripts of his imaginary abduction sessions (he has published none so far) and we can see what McCall was saying as he led his subjects through their "abductions." I bring up this point because in 1979 I watched Dr. McCall work with a hypnotized abductee. I also examined some tapes of his sessions with other subjects and on one or two occasions noted that he was asking some very leading questions. By any proper experimental criterion, Lawson should have used a clinician unfamiliar with the UFO literature.

continued...

The Case of the Imaginary Abductions

But this was only the first of Lawson's improper procedures. His next major experimental error came after he had collected his data. *Convinced that the content of his imaginary abduction scenarios matched the content of real-life cases, even down to the small details, he chose four accounts post-hoc from the literature and pointed out the considerable coincidences between them and imaginary abduction reports.*

It is all too apparent that bias, both conscious and unconscious, could have played a role in Lawson's selection process. For example, he fails to show his readers that his "control reports" were chosen in such a way as to minimize his own possible bias. He could easily have chosen these cases (even unconsciously) because they did indeed match the information in his imaginary reports.

For Lawson's comparisons to be valid, the control cases should have been chosen randomly by a researcher unfamiliar with the specific hypothesis Lawson was testing. This researcher should also have been blind to what Lawson's experimental subjects had previously reported. The allegation that real and imaginary abduction reports are indistinguishable is crucial to Lawson's position; unfortunately, not once did he attempt to obtain objective verification of this hypothesis. His conclusion is little more than a post-hoc finding, based on nothing other than his own subjective impressions.

To compound his errors, Lawson tried to show how specific patterns and details commonly appear in both imaginary and real-life reports. His process of selection was again entirely post-hoc and about as scientific as asking subjects to describe an imaginary cat, collecting reports of real cats, extracting whatever common descriptions there might be, and then concluding that all cats are imaginary.

The tragedy of this is that Lawson could easily have properly tested his hunch that real and imaginary abduction stories are indistinguishable. Experimental psychology has developed all sorts of techniques by which two sets of data can be objectively and meaningfully compared.

Lawson should have compiled a series of transcripts from his imaginary reports after carefully removing any hints that they were bogus stories. These could have been randomly mixed in with a similar set of genuine

accounts, then turned over to an independent (blind) judge familiar with the UFO literature. The judge's job would be to read over the entire set of transcripts and attempt to determine which were the imaginary reports and which were not, based solely on their content. There are statistical tests that can be applied to the results. These would tell us whether there were significant clues with the reports that enabled the judge to tell them apart. (Lawson, of course, would be betting that the judge could not tell the difference between the real and the bogus narratives.)

Although it is just about the only way Lawson's theory could be tested objectively, this simple experiment has never been conducted—even though I suggested it to him in 1977.

To be fair, it should be noted that Lawson and his colleagues have made at least one attempt to quantify their two sets of data. They broke down the information content of the two groups of reports into eight categories to

see how many information bits fit into each. (For example, they counted how many aspects of "strangeness" found their way into the imaginary and control cases.) They found similar overall patterns in the data, which Lawson outlined in his paper "Hypnosis of Imaginary UFO 'Abductees'" (in Curtis G. Fuller [ed.], *Proceedings of the First International UFO Congress* [1980]).

While they appear significant, once again it appears that these breakdowns were made by researchers (i.e., Lawson and McCall) already familiar with the hypothesis being tested—a fact that may well have affected the manner in which they made their classifications. Lawson has even admitted that "the quantification attempt is no doubt unscientific in many ways. The categories are imperfect and the analyses based upon them are subjective and imprecise."

Readers of Lawson's report will observe that *the similarities he has found are taken totally out of context.* So while Lawson might

TIME FACTOR/ EVENT

MRS. X

MISS Z.

Landing of the UFO and prelude to the abduction

Saw a light in a window, and felt as though a vacuum had engulfed the house.

Saw a light through a window and noted sense of oppression and silence coming over the house.

Entry of aliens

Teleported into the house through a closed door.

Teleported into the house through a closed window.

Size of aliens

Noted two sizes: a few aliens taller than the others.

Noted two sizes: some aliens several inches taller than the others.

Nature of the aliens

Noted an aura of friendliness about the aliens but felt so in their power that she had no ability to act against their wishes or defy them in any way.

Was curiously unafraid of them as though they were friends but also noted that, as soon as they entered, they were in complete control of the situation and she could not rebel against them.

Journey to the UFO

Floated to the UFO by the aliens.

Floated along a beam of light to the UFO.

Ordeals aboard the UFO

Hovered over a table and was given a medical examination.

Hovered over a table and was given an medical examination.

Communication with the aliens

Telepathic.

Telepathic.

Reaction to the aliens and the examination

Felt pain at one point but an alien relieved the pain by touching her head.

Felt alarmed when seeing the aliens, but they alleviated it by petting her.

Aftermath of the abduction

Several more UFO like visitations and fleeting memories of an abduction.

Developed unusual obsessions and extraordinary desire to study medicine.

GEPAN - A Statement by Its Director

by Jean Jacques Velasco

In 1977, GEPAN was set up at the French Space Agency (CNES). At its head was Monsieur C. Poher, an engineer who had already worked for many years in his own right on statistical and other aspects of the subject. A scientific advisory body was set up to monitor and give direction to GEPAN's activities. The first tasks undertaken by GEPAN were:

- 1) setting up data collection systems operated in conjunction with the Air Force, the Gendarmerie (French internal police), weather services, etc;
- 2) inquiries into previously reported cases;
- 3) statistical analysis of eye-witness reports.

This initial stage uncovered two basic truths:

a) the appearance of certain unidentified phenomena cannot be accommodated by conventional physical or psychological models;

b) a physical component in the phenomena reported is extremely likely.

The second stage consisted in adding greater rigor and a more theoretical approach to the studies. The question arose as to whether scientific method could be applied to the study of unidentified flying objects.

A major difficulty in our type of work is the fact that we have no control over conditions of observation and that the information we uncover is of such a varied nature. Another ob-

stacle is the fact that data are gathered "after the event." Our original aim, therefore, was to develop a method with which to analyze the differences, with a view to developing a general model.

GEPAN has organized and drawn up a number of agreements with national public organizations which supply and process data. These include the Gendarmerie Nationale, the Air Force, Navy, weather services and so on. Such organizations deliver data in the form of reports, video tapes, films, etc., which are then processed and analyzed by GEPAN. GEPAN receives Gendarmerie reports on a regular basis. By December 1983, we had received 1,514 reports dating back to 1974.

High peaks or waves of reportings generally arise from either an exceptional event

continued on page 12...

reasonably argue that his imaginary narratives parallel real-life cases in a very general way, he certainly cannot say that his reports conform to the precise pattern of real-life cases.

For example, his research fails to explain how two different victims of time-lapse abductions will sometimes recall (usually under hypnosis) virtually identical experiences. These similarities will often be so complex and will follow the same specific sequence of experience that it appears as if the accounts were copied from each other.

The table on page 4 compares two abduction cases I have extracted from the literature. The percipients, whom for purposes of the table I will call Mrs. X and Miss Z, both were abducted at night from their homes.

Mrs. X's account is taken from the story Betty Andreasson told under hypnosis to Raymond Fowler. Her abduction in 1967 in Massachusetts was uncovered in 1977 and published in 1979. Miss Z, on the other hand, was a victim of an abduction that took place in 1953 in a desolate canyon near Los Angeles, was unearthed through hypnosis in 1975 and was published in 1980. (I participated in the investigation, which is chronicled in *The Tujunga Canyon Contacts*, by Ann Druffel

and me.) Although virtually identical, these cases occurred on opposite sides of the continent and were separated in time by 14 years. Nothing was known about the Andreasson affair when our subject, Sara Shaw, was regressed. Nor was anything published on the Shaw case at the time Andreasson remembered her experience. No borrowing from each other's story could possibly have taken place.

So what is the scientific status of Lawson's theory that there exist no substantial differences between real and imaginary abduction reports? In my view he has made some very interesting observations; these, however, should not be confused with documented findings. The fact of the matter is that nearly all of Lawson's conclusions are based on a post-hoc comparison and selection of data. The canons of experimental science dictate that a conclusion can never be based on a post-hoc finding. Such a finding can be used only to generate a hypothesis to be tested under controlled experimental conditions.

Lawson has made several observations that would allow him to suggest that there are meaningful coincidences linking real-life and imaginary abduction reports. But so far no objective test of this theory has been forth-

coming—at least no test (structured along the lines I outlined earlier) that specifically restricted the experimenter's own bias.

I would like to make it clear that I have not come to these conclusions out of any emotionally-based dislike for the point Lawson is trying to make. My skepticism comes solely from the self-evident fact that Lawson's research violates several canons of proper experimental procedure.

In the next issue of *IUR* D. Scott Rogo critically examines Lawson's "birth trauma" explanation for UFO abduction reports. ■

We apologize for the lateness of this and the previous issue of *IUR*. CUFOS has been undergoing reorganization in the wake of the Hyneks' move to Arizona. One of the many changes involved has been finding a new printer in the Chicago area. Under the circumstances delays were inevitable. We hope to be back on a regular publication schedule soon. Meantime, we thank readers for their patience.

— The Editors.

"BLACK HOLE" Over Baltimore

by Bruce Maccabee

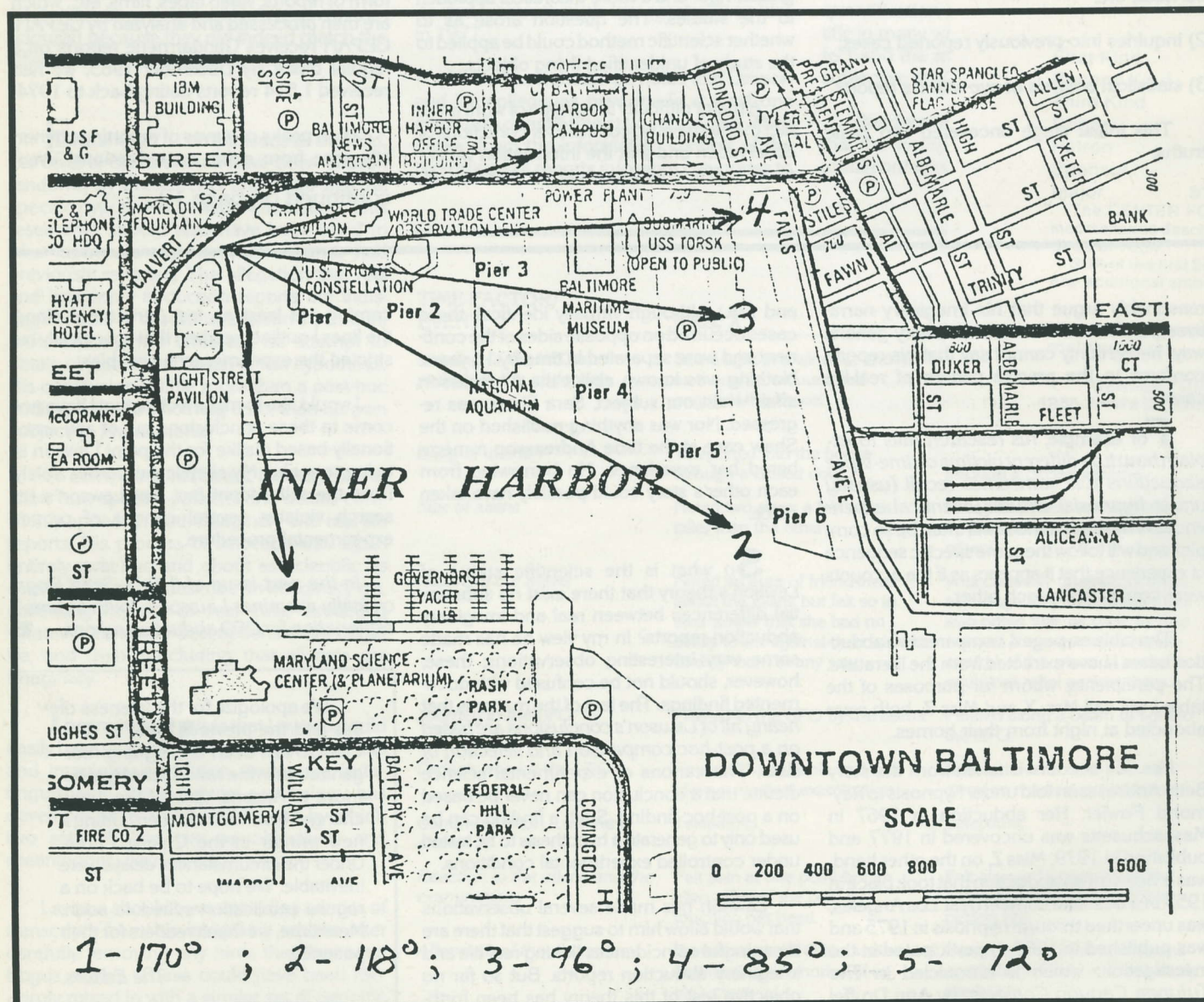
Editor's Note: While it is not uncommon for technically-trained individuals to report a UFO sighting, rarely does a member of the CUFOS Scientific Board make such a report. Bruce Maccabee, associated with CUFOS and the Fund for UFO Research for several years, a physicist with the Naval Surface Weapons Lab, recently had his own UFO experience. In this account of the incident, it

is interesting to follow Maccabee's reasoning as he observed the "spot" and followed the typical pattern of "escalation of hypotheses" so much in evidence in many sightings. It is also instructive to see how a skilled observer goes about recording his visual impressions; his accurate observations serve as a model for future witnesses to the UFO phenomenon.

TYPE:
DATE:
TIME:
DURATION:
WITNESSES:
PLACE:

DD
September 2, 1984
Just before 7:28 p.m. EDT
7 minutes
2
Baltimore

The French Army under Napoleon had just invaded Russia when I first saw it...a tiny



black spot against the bright blue sky. The invasion, as portrayed musically by Tchaikovsky in the 1812 Overture, was proceeding smoothly, with cannon firing. I was admiring the clear evening sky and just randomly looking around at the crowd of people standing near the band shell in the Inner Harbor in Baltimore (see map). Directly east of me was a wooden battleship *Constellation* with its three high masts. The top of the highest mast was about 170 feet above my altitude. South-southeast of me was a modern steel battleship with radar and other antennas above its highest deck. It was while casually glancing at this ship that I first noticed the "black hole."

I couldn't identify it immediately when I first saw it, but I wasn't impressed. I could see a number of dark "spots"—birds—moving around in the sky. I assumed that this particular "spot" would resolve itself into something recognizable and returned my gaze to the scene in front of me. But, as my eyes wandered back and forth over the Inner Harbor area of Baltimore, I again looked southeastward. By comparing the direction of the black spot with the direction of the superstructure of the steel ship, I could see that the spot was moving steadily toward my left (northward). I was surprised that I still couldn't see it well enough to identify it, so I started to observe it intently. After watching the spot for about 10 seconds, I decided that it was sufficiently odd that I would make a note of what time I had first seen it (I have trained myself to do this whenever I decide that something in the sky looks unusual, just in case...). Looking at my digital watch, I saw that it read 7:28 (subsequently I found that my watch was 1.5 minutes fast).

Fifteen or so seconds later I looked back toward the steel battleship. The direction to the "black hole" had changed considerably. It had moved farther northward and was higher in the sky than before. It also appeared larger in angular size. I was disturbed that I couldn't see any details of the object other than its outline against the sky. I had the impression that the shape of the outline was changing continuously as it moved northward. I pointed it out to my wife, Christine, and then looked around at the crowd nearby. Several people appeared to be looking in the direction of the black object. I began to watch it intently.

What is it? I kept asking myself. I could imagine trying to describe it to someone: "Well, it had no shape...it was amorphous." But that wouldn't have been correct, because it did have a specific outline against the sky at

any instant in time. But the outline was continually changing as it moved. There appeared to be a slight wave, like an ocean wave, moving in a counterclockwise direction around its edge. I thought of a wheel "rolling" through the sky, although there were no spokes or hub. I had the feeling that it would eventually rotate into such an orientation that I could see wings or something that would identify it. It appeared to go through a cycle of shape change. For a period of time (estimated at 5-10 seconds) the outline was quite round and it changed very slightly. Then over the next 10-15 seconds the outline became more elliptical or cigar-shaped and finally over the last 10-15 seconds of the cycle the ellipticity decreased and the outline became generally round again. During each cycle as the outline became more elliptical I had the impression that it would become "airplane-shaped" (as an airplane seen broadside from below).

I concentrated on trying to see the wings. Yet the only evidence of a wing that I could see was a short protrusion that appeared at the top of the object when the outline was elliptical or cigar-shaped. I continued to concentrate on the bottom of the outline of the object looking for the "lower" wing, but my efforts were in vain. Nor could I see any "tailfin" such as would appear at the rear of the plane. I could not even see any part of the object moving in front of or in back of any other part. In fact, there didn't seem to be any three-dimensionality. From what I could see the object could have been two-dimensional, a flat black object with an outline that changed shape as it traveled through the sky.

I was also puzzled by the lack of brightness highlights within the outline of the object. It seemed to me that it was high enough to be illuminated by the setting sun, yet there appeared to be no surface reflections. It was as if some oddly structured three-dimensional object had been painted with flat black paint so that it would not reflect any light, and then the object continually rotated in a complex way while travelling through the sky.

Although I kept a close watch on this object over the next minute or so, I repeatedly cast my gaze elsewhere for short periods of time in order to compare it with other things in the sky. There were numerous birds flying around at various distances. I had no trouble identifying them, even when they were so far away that their bodies were mere dots against the sky. I also saw a commercial jet about to land at Baltimore-Washington Airport. It was about five miles south of me at an angular elevation of about 5-10 degrees. Although all I could make out was the fuselage, I could see gradations of brightness from the curved, greyish metallic surface as it reflected the light of the setting sun. I could also see gradations of brightness on the bodies and wings of the birds. Gradations of brightness are characteristic of a three-dimensional object. Yet try as I might—and believe me, I tried—I could not see any gradations of brightness associated with the black spot. It seemed to be totally black. It was as if I were looking at a "hole" in the sky, a black hole into which all the illuminating light had fallen and none was coming back out.

About a minute after I first saw the object, the sighting line passed almost over the *Constellation*. I asked my wife what she thought. She suggested that it was about the size of a kite, perhaps a box kite. I did not buy this, however. No kite would travel the angular distance this object had travelled without rising up into the sky. Furthermore, it did not have the right shape or outline for either an ordinary flat kite or a box kite.

I decided that things were getting serious. I knew that I had binoculars in the back of our stationwagon about half a mile away in a parking lot. Should I run and get them? I would have to make a mad dash through the crowd to get them, and would it be worth it?

As I watched the object and thought about the binoculars, it continued to move steadily northward. The angular elevation and the angular size both increased, and now my line of sight passed directly over masts of the

continued...

"It was as if I were looking at a 'hole' in the sky, a black hole into which all illuminating light had fallen"

"In about two minutes this black object had traveled an angular distance...of about 60 degrees"

Constellation. I decided that if I only waited and watched carefully the object would "give itself away." I concentrated on the object, looking for the slightest evidence of surface reflection. I kept thinking that the moment of identification was at hand.

But it wasn't. The object reached its highest angle of elevation when it was in the direction of the *Constellation*, almost due east of me. Apparently that was the point of closest approach because then the elevation began to decrease while it was still traveling northward at an essentially steady rate. When it was at its closest, I had stuck up my arm to compare the angular size of the object with the angular size of my little finger. It was much smaller than my finger, but it did have apparent size. By subsequent measurement, I concluded that the maximum angular size was in the range .50 to 1.00 millimeter at arm's length, corresponding to an angular size of one to two milliradians (e.g., a size of one to two feet at a distance of 1,000 feet). As the object continued to move northward, the angular size shrank and the angle of elevation decreased. I was still debating whether or not to run for the binoculars when my view of the object was cut off by the southern corner of the World Trade Center (see map). The elevation of the sighting line was a few floors below the top of the building, which I found later to be about 405 feet high and about 720 feet from where I stood. This means the elevation at this moment in the sighting was about 26 degrees.

I looked at my watch. It read 7:30. In about two minutes this black object had traveled an angular distance which I estimated at the time to be about 60 degrees (actually it was about 70 degrees). I estimated that the Trade Center building was only about 10 degrees wide, so I expected the object to appear on its other side in a relatively short time, certainly no more than half a minute.

Accordingly, I returned my attention to the orchestra playing right in front of me. I would glance to the north of the Trade Center

building every 10 or 15 seconds, expecting to see the object appear again. But it hadn't appeared after about 30 seconds. So I waited some more. The Russian-French battle was really heating up...and I was getting nervous, still waiting for the reappearance.

I began to worry and looked at my watch. It read 7:31, and still no object. Could it have disappeared? Finally it reappeared, considerably smaller in angular size than before. My watch read 7:32. The object had taken about a minute and a half to two minutes to change its azimuth by only about 10 degrees, whereas the previous two minutes (7:28-7:30), it had changed its azimuth by about 60 degrees. Why did it take so long? I decided that it must have changed direction of flight while it was hidden from me and was now heading more eastward. I continued to watch carefully. The line-of-sight to the object still moved northward, but very slowly now. In fact, during the last couple of minutes that the object was visible, it seemed to maintain a constant azimuth (see map) and a nearly constant elevation. I watched as it shrank to a tiny dot, and eventually I could no longer see it against the sky. My watch read 7:35.

During the last couple of minutes the object was evidently traveling directly away from me toward the east-northeast, since the azimuth didn't change noticeably. It did not seem to be traveling with the surface wind, which was from the south-southeast, as indicated by the numerous flags that were in the area. Its actual altitude, though, must have increased slightly to compensate for the increased distance, since it appeared to maintain nearly a constant elevation angle during these last two minutes.

As the object shrank in apparent size to a barely visible dot, I compared it to a distant bird. The bird was so far away that its body appeared as an unresolved black dot against the sky. But I knew it was a bird because I could see the effect of the wings flapping. At its closest the angular size of the object had

been much greater than the angular size of this bird. So why hadn't I been able to see any details of the object? I wished I had run for my binoculars. In thinking about the sighting afterward I realized that there was a second reason for running for the binoculars: I would have changed my position on the ground enough to give myself a baseline for a crude estimate of the altitude of the object.

After the concert was over, Christine and I left the Inner Harbor and drove to her parents' house in a suburb of Baltimore. While there I wrote down what I could remember of the sighting, made sketches of the object, asked Christine to do the same, and called a radio station (WBAL) to find out if it had received any reports. It had not.

In the light of subsequent investigation and reflection, it seems very unlikely that the object was any of the following: a bird, since the wings, head and body should have been visually resolved; a kite, since the flight dynamics did not match that of a tethered kite; an aircraft, since a plane or helicopter should have been easily recognized, given the object's angular size; or a balloon, since analysis of the wind speed and direction at various altitudes reveals that the velocity of the object was more than twice the measured wind speed at any reasonable altitude. Also the continual change in shape is not consistent with the round or teardrop shape of a balloon.

My sighting is unexplainable, but the "black hole" didn't do anything spectacular. It just traveled at an apparently constant rate over the Inner Harbor of Baltimore. It made no noise, so far as I could tell, that would attract attention to it. I expect that people who did notice it thought it was peculiar, but then ignored it. Had it been a silvery disc glinting in the sunset as it travelled along, I'm sure it would have been reported by hundreds of people. But this object was just not flashy. Its major peculiarity was its extreme blackness. It was of such a small angular size (at least from my location) that it posed no apparent threat to anyone. It just shouldn't have been there—or anywhere—but probably most of the witnesses didn't realize that.

Compared with Others

At the time of my sighting, it seemed to me that black UFOs had been reported before, but I could not remember any particular sightings except a few photographic cases in which portions of the objects were dark or black. I did not remember reading about any

sightings similar to my own. After I had completed the above report, I made a brief search of the literature and was surprised to find that black objects had been seen long before my sighting. In fact, the first report of a black object in the sky was made by a reporter, Dave Johnson, in July 1947. He was flying in a small plane looking for "flying saucers" to confirm Arnold's sighting when he saw a black object come out of a distant cloud. He photographed the object, but it was too distant to make a useful image on the film.

While reading through early reports recently released by the army, I came, quite by chance, upon the following report, which has never before been published. The report was made by Norman H. Brown, Acting Chief, Review and Analysis Section, Atomic Energy Commission. It was filed as an "Air Space Violation at Oak Ridge, Tennessee" on July 27, 1953. The report reads as follows:

At approximately 3:00 P.M. on July 19, 1953, an F-86 aircraft was observed flying over Oak Ridge residential area, making circles at what appeared to the writer to be approximately 2,500 or 3,500 feet. The F-86 flew over the area in this manner for approximately 10 or 15 minutes. The writer, together with his wife, observed the aircraft through a pair of six power field glasses. After aircraft flew in what appeared to be the direction of Knoxville, Tennessee, a black object moved out of a high white cloud, directly over the area the F-86 had been flying. This object began to travel at a tremendous speed, in a large circle. This action on the part of the unknown object continued for at least five minutes. During the circle of this object, it appeared at times to be in the shape of a cigar and at other times round. This object was extremely black in color, having an appearance of a deep black metal exterior with a fine gloss. It did not leave a vapor trail nor were there any lights shine (sic) noticed. No sound was heard. The object flew east at a tremendous speed for what appeared to be approximately three miles where it stopped. The object (sic) was then joined by two more of these same objects. A formation similar to a spread 'V' was formed and the objects, at a tremendous speed flew in an eastward direction.

Upon reading this report I was struck in particular by the description of the blackness of the object and also by the description of the object looking round part of the time and cigar-shaped part of the time. ■

LETTERS

To the editor:

We would like to respond to several points raised by George M. Eberhart in his review of our book *Clear Intent* (IUR, July-August 1984).

1) Eberhart cites the March 25, 1949, FBI memo which concludes that UFOs may be man-made and that the U.S.S.R. had experimented on an "unknown type of flying disc." He criticizes us for not writing "volumes of commentary" on this and on a January 26, 1976, CIA document on possible UFO propulsion.

Regarding the 1949 FBI memo: where would all those volumes of commentary have gotten us? It would have brought us right back to the statement that we made—and that Eberhart also mentions—expressing our doubt that the report was accurate. The rest of *Clear Intent* provides evidence that UFOs are not man-made vehicles from Russia or any other nation on earth.

The portion of the 1976 CIA document made available to the public obviously leads into highly technical subject matter which we, who are not authorities on magnetohydrodynamics or superconductivity at low temperatures, are technically untrained to evaluate. On page 220 we did ask people with knowledge of the events to contact us with further information.

2) Merely because we chose to include certain documents in the book, no reader ought automatically to conclude that we accepted at face value all the claims made in those documents. In the case of the Polish POW who supposedly knew of Nazi-operated flying saucers: a) the witness is unnamed; b) there is no follow-up information in the file; and c) the authors weren't there during the sighting, do not know the witness and must rely on the document as the sole source of information until more comes along.

3) Our book makes quite clear what "zoo events" refers to. The quote is taken from the *Ad Hoc Panel on the September 22 Event* exactly as it appears. We explain that the term is being used as a synonym for an unidentified light flash. Why Eberhart would assume that the name is a typographical error for "200" is beyond us.

4) Where is it said in *Clear Intent* that we have uncritically accepted the Walesville, New York, plane crash as a "UFO-induced"? On page 62 we wrote, "Without the full details of the crash, it is impossible to determine what caused the jet to malfunction." Is this "uncritical acceptance"?

Eberhart goes on to mention Donald Keyhoe's *Aliens From Space* as if it were some piece of absurd tabloid fluff when we quote from it to counter the Air Force's claim that the Kinross case is explainable as an RCAF C-47 aircraft. Keyhoe's source for the assertion that the C-47 was not the UFO is the Royal Canadian Air Force itself!

5) Eberhart wants to know why we did not mention Lee Merkel's IFO chase in 1954. He seems to think this is important. Why? What connection does the IFO chase have to Merkel's unfortunate death on January 31, 1956? Merkel's son did not mention the IFO chase to us because he was unaware of it. He was very young at that time and could barely remember his father. Young Lee's knowledge of his father came mainly through his mother and a later quest for information on the crash, as is recounted in *Clear Intent*.

Our book was never intended to be the final word on UFO secrecy. It is only a first step to what we hope is the eventual resolution of this most complicated problem.

Larry Fawcett
Coventry, Connecticut

Barry J. Greenwood
Stoneham, Massachusetts

To the editor:

Concerning "mass hysteria"—which Willy Smith and Jerome Clark discuss in connection with the "mad gasser of Mattoon" (IUR, November-December 1984)—I think this phenomenon is well worth studying since it may be an element in, for example, UFO flaps. The question I have is this: who has *really* studied mass hysteria?

Every so often a "classic" case occurs, one in which a factory full of workers or a school full of children get sick—and there's no physical cause, supposedly. There have

continued on page 11...



Figure 1: The camp at Hessdalen was atop a plateau above the tree line. A few hardy souls slept and cooked in these tents but the majority of us found shelter in Hessdalen.

Tracking the Hessdalen Lights

by J. Allen Hynek

After the considerable success of Project Hessdalen I (1984), UFO Norway and UFO Sweden, assisted by some members of university and military groups, mounted Project Hessdalen II, covering the period from January 14 to February 2, 1985. I was invited to attend as a member of their scientific advisory group even though I could be present for only part of the time.

When I arrived in Oslo on January 25, I was met by Odd-Gunnar Roed and immediately driven to Hessdalen, which is less than four degrees from the Arctic Circle. The journey was not without incident. Near Roras, along the "roof" of Norway, which has the reputation of being one of the two coldest spots in the nation, our car froze—very fortunately not far from a farmhouse. With the temperature at -34°F ., any extended hiking for assistance would have been highly unlikely. Eventually we made the additional 20 miles to Hessdalen.

The camp (see Figure 1) was some miles further on, atop a plateau above the tree line. A few hardy souls slept and cooked in these tents but the majority of us found shelter in Hessdalen through the kindness of some residents who had taken a great interest in the search for the mysterious lights.

I was impressed by the dedication of those Norwegian and Swedish ufologists who, without pay and at their own expense, taking time from their own work, kept the lonely vigil during the dark the of cold arctic nights. The temperature at the camp during my stay was always below zero (at -15°F . the shutters of my cameras froze shut) and meals and the amenities had to be pursued in the most primitive manner. (The work of UFO Sweden and some of its leaders appeared in the July-August issue of *IUR* and a similar story about UFO Norway will soon appear.)

The Hessdalen lights are certainly no spectator of persons or their dedication. In contrast to the significant results obtained during Project Hessdalen I, the 1985 project was disappointing. The best photographs by far were obtained a few weeks before the project started; they were taken by an Oslo-based investigative journalist named Arne Wisth, who has independently pursued the elusive lights for several years. On December 30, 1984, in the course of a one-man expedition to Hessdalen, he obtained the two photographs shown on the cover and in Figure 2. He has kindly furnished me with the original negatives as well as with the enlargements shown here. These

two shots represent the same object taken just a few seconds apart. The marked changes in the interval are striking.

Wisth has written a book about the Hessdalen lights, unfortunately in Norwegian which, however, he virtually translated for me in the course of two afternoons. (Readers interested in the book or in the abbreviated translation may make appropriate arrangements to obtain them through CUFOS.)

UFO Norway and UFO Sweden have published an excellent 75-page report (compiled by Erling Strand) on the 1984 Project Hessdalen. It did not come from the printer until Project Hessdalen 1985 was already well underway. Because this report is virtually unavailable in the United States, I present the highlights here:

Hessdalen is a valley in the middle part of Norway, near Trondheim. About 150 persons live in this eight-mile-long valley. The nearest town, Roras, is some 20 miles away.

In December 1981 variously-colored lights of unknown origin began to appear. The lights could remain stationary for more than an hour, move around slowly or streak through the sky at extreme speed, as much as several miles per second (according to radar).

The apparent size of the lights was small, often no greater than a bright planet or an airplane landing light. At various times they appeared high in the air, over housetops or on the ground. They were often seen in the valley and were visible against the mountainside. Photograph enlargement showed them to be bullet-shaped (with the sharp end down) or as round as a soccer ball. They could change form in a matter of seconds. Frequently they showed periodic flashing.

Although occasionally seen in the daytime (especially at dusk), they were primarily nocturnal. Sometimes they were multiple, the lights generally holding a fixed pattern. They displayed a preference for a north-south course. In character they were entirely unlike the "northern lights," which among other differences cover a large area of the sky.

While the natives speak of them as "UFOs" (which they are in the sense that they are unidentified), the Norwegian and Swedish scientists tend to regard them as a natural phenomenon—which leaves unanswered the glaring questions of why these lights were absent until 1981. Some researchers have speculated that the phenomena are man-made, possibly representing experiments with "particle rays."

On two occasions a laser light was directed toward a periodically flashing light. Immediately the light doubled its flash period, only to resume its normal flashing pattern. As soon as the laser was again directed toward it, the flashing doubled. This occurred a total of eight out of nine times, straining coincidence and suggesting intelligent behavior.

Besides cameras of various focal lengths, the project staff used radar, an IR viewer, a geiger counter, a laser, a seismograph, a spectrum analyzer and a magnetometer—all this under extremely difficult observing conditions. ■

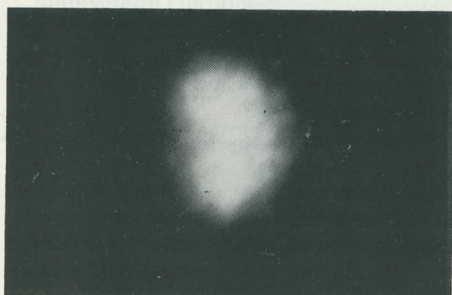


Figure 2: This photo and the one on the cover represent the same object taken just a few seconds apart. Note the marked changes.

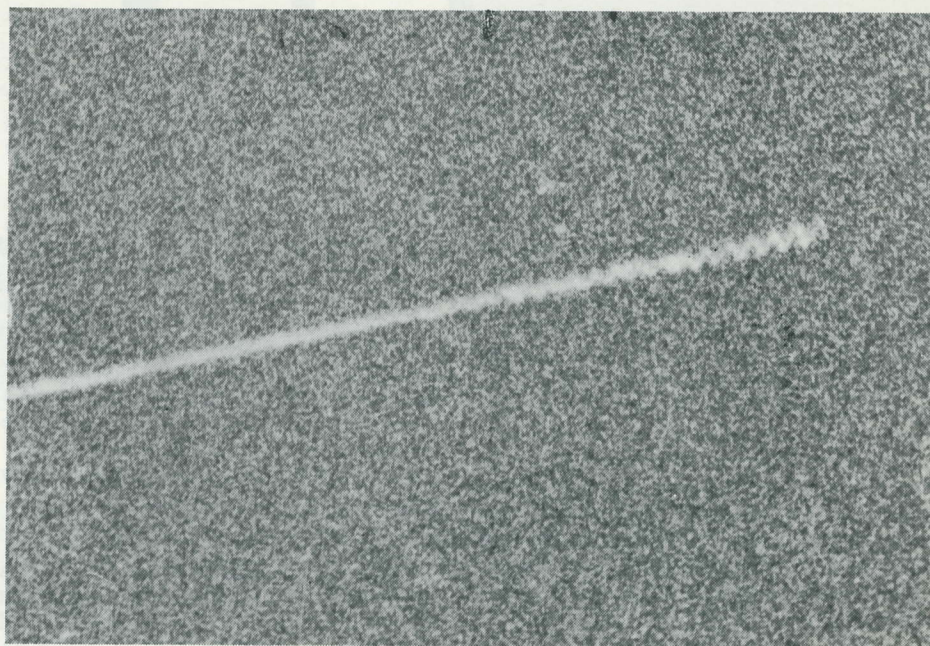


Figure 3: This 10-second time exposure was taken by Roar Wister at 7:23 P.M. on February 21, 1984.



Figure 4: Appearing in front of a mountain, this light was traveling to the left down the valley. The photo was taken by Leif Havik on February 12, 1984.

been some school cases in Chicago in the last four or five years in which there was a cause: bad food, chemicals or pesticides. My impression is that there's no discernible difference in how these things develop, whether they're laid to food poisoning or to mass hysteria.

If anyone has compared and really made sure that the "hysteria" cases have no physical causes, I don't know of it.

Frank John Reid
Chicago

LETTERS

continued

A good book on this subject, examining mass hysteria from a variety of perspectives (historical, sociological, psychological and medical), is *Mass Psychogenic Illness* (Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Hillsdale, New Jersey, 1982), edited by Michael J. Colligan, James W. Pennebaker and Lawrence R. Murphy.

—The Editors ■

GEPAN continued

(rumors, setting up of GEPAN, TV or radio program, etc.) or simply a large number of observations. There has been a clear drop in reportings since 1981.

Analysis and expert appraisal of Gendarmerie reports produce a six-way classification of phenomena: astronomical (confusion with stars, planets, etc.); aeronautical (confusion with aircraft); space (satellites, etc.); meteorological, miscellaneous; and unidentified. Statistical analysis of reports reveals considerable variation in types of cases and permits us to make a breakdown by type. However, a number of problems inherent in the statistical methods adopted soon became apparent: inadequate amounts of additional information, too rigid encoding procedures, too few cases and, above all, the problem of unidentified cases.

Landing Traces

This inquiry, initiated by a request from a Gendarmerie, was conducted by GEPAN in February 1981. At about 5:00 p.m. on February 8, 1981, Monsieur Collini was working quietly in his garden at Trans in Provence. Suddenly, his attention was attracted by a low whistling sound that appeared to come from the far end of his property. Turning around, he saw in the sky above the trees something approaching a terrace at the bottom of the garden. Less than a minute later, the object suddenly rose and moved away in a direction similar to the direction it had come from, while continuing to emit a low whistle.

M. Collini immediately went to the apparent scene of the landing and observed circular marks and a clear crown-shaped imprint on the ground. The Gendarmerie arrived the next day to report and following our instructions took samples from the ground and surrounding vegetation. A GEPAN team was sent to investigate. The first results proved positive.

During this inquiry we studied the observable dimensions, drawing on the skills of various specialist laboratories, for example a human science laboratory for analysis of the witness report, physics and chemistry laboratories to study the ground, and a biochemistry laboratory for the vegetation.

No evidence indicated that the witness suffered from psychological problems. On the contrary, there was great internal and external consistency between the various versions of the witness' report, and a minimum element of subjectivity (given the physical evidence).

Physico-chemical analyses of the ground, based on the disturbances observed (visible imprint), demonstrated a qualitatively large-scale incident producing a depression of the ground, heating to between 300° and 600° C. and probably the depositing of trace quantities of materials such as phosphate and zinc.

Samples were taken to investigate whether the surrounding vegetation had been disturbed. This work was carried out in line with instructions from GEPAN and the biochem-

istry laboratory of INRA (Institut National de la Recherche Agronomique) under Professeur Bounias.

Analyses were made of the chlorophyll and carotenoid pigment content of a species of wild alfalfa (*medicago minima*) growing in the immediate area. Leaves in the immediate vicinity were observed to have 30% to 50% reduction in chlorophyll pigments A and B. Young leaf shoots underwent the highest losses and showed signs of premature senescence. There was significant correlation between the disturbances observed and the distance from the center of the phenomena. The correlation phenomenon-distance appears beyond dispute.

The effects on plants in the area can be compared with that produced on the leaves of other plant species after exposing the seeds to gamma radiation. Data show that a considerable amount of gamma radiation (10— rads) must be applied to produce a disturbance equal to that observed at the site. Should we consider the presence of ionizing (nuclear) radiation? Almost certainly not, since no measurable residual radioactivity is present in the plants. However, could the trauma be caused by an electromagnetic field? This is almost certainly the case.

This first case of scientific examination based on the alleged sighting of an unidentified airborne phenomenon does not allow us to draw conclusions as to the identity or nature of the phenomenon. The inquiry raises more questions than it answers, but we feel that at least the questions have been asked in the right terms. ■

STOP!!! CHECK YOUR MAILING LABEL DATE

If the date shown on your label is 3/85, this is the anniversary of your last contribution to CUFOS and this is the last issue of IJR you will receive until your next contribution is received by CUFOS. Thank you very much for your continued support. Action now will continue you mailings uninterrupted.

Center for UFO Studies

1955 John's Drive
Glenview, Illinois 60025

Nonprofit Organization
U.S. Postage
PAID
Glenview, Illinois